Acceptance Certificates

The Ayush ministry must push for rigorous treatment protocol based on science and ensure new and high-quality products

By SONALI ACHARJEE



J.P. GANPATRAO, *63* | SHIV SENA
MoS (IC) Minister of AYUSH

↘ **An experienced hand** Born in Mehkar, Maharashtra, Shiv Sena leader Ganpatrao has been elected MP for a fourth time from Buldhana in 2024. Earlier, he has held portfolios of sports, youth welfare and irrigation in Maharashtra from 1997 to 1999

↘ **Policy nous** Since his election to the Lok Sabha in 2009, he has been chairperson of the Standing Committees on Rural Development and Panchayati Raj and Communications and IT

↘ **Pledge for life** He celebrated his new role by planting a sapling and pledging to donate his organs

After the Patanjali misleading advertisements case, the pressure is on the ministry of Ayush, by now a familiar acronym for traditional health systems like Ayurveda, Yoga, Unani, Siddha and Homoeopathy, to bridge the gap between traditional and modern medicine systems. To raise awareness, the ministry aims to set up 12,500 Ayush health and wellness centres, which can help bring down both the disease burden and out-of-pocket expense in the country. Since 2014, under the National Ayush Mission, the ministry has also released Rs 719 crore to southern states/UTs to build their traditional medicine infrastructure. ■

▶WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

MORE CLINICAL TRIALS
There is growing demand for a more evidence-based treatment protocol within traditional medicine. In 2017, for example, homoeopathic drugs were pushed by the ministry to treat chikungunya and dengue, but without scientific basis or clinical trials

CURBING MISLEADING ADVERTISEMENTS
In 2017, a ministry pamphlet for pregnant women to stop eating meat, having sex and impure thoughts, stirred up a controversy. In April 2020, the Advertising Standards Council of India flagged 50 campaigns offering Covid-19 cures by homoeopathic drugmakers. Anything non-scientific must be banned from advertising

IMPROVING QUALITY CONTROL
A 2008 *Lancet* study found a fifth of ayurvedic medicines manufactured in India and the US to contain high levels of heavy metals, including lead, mercury and arsenic compounds. Ayush medicines need to be held to the same regulatory standards as allopathic medicines

PRODUCT RESEARCH
The ministry must design and make new products and introduce technology like automation

AYUSH DOCTORS/ PRESCRIPTION
The matter of giving Ayush doctors the right to prescribe allopathic drugs is pending resolution